drop zone where a small bunch of men were still standing firm under the command of a twenty-one-year old second lieutenant, Amar Jit Singh Behl.

By 8 October, a detachment of 17 Para Field from Agra had arrived at Tezpur and moved by road to Tsangdhar, reporting to 7 Brigade. The two serviceable guns that had been airdropped at Tsangdhar were deployed near the drop zone and the track running from Nam Ka Chu went past the left flank of this position. On 16 October, the senior officer in the party, Captain Harjeet Singh Talwar, was asked to proceed to Tsangle at Bridge 5 and do a reconnaissance of the Chinese positions on the Thagla Ridge. His party was to follow Monpa guides who were ferrying loads for the Punjab company at Tsangle. Along the way it started to snow heavily. The Monpas jettisoned their loads and melted away, leaving the disoriented officer and his party to find their own way back.

For forty-eight hours the party wandered around in circles, unable to navigate in the mist and snow. One of the soldiers developed frostbite and for a while it looked as if the entire party would die of exposure. Fortunately, on the night of 18 October, they ran into a flank patrol, which took them back to 2 Rajput's Charlie Company deployed at the Temporary Bridge. Major Sharan Sethi and Subedar Dashrath Singh took the exhausted party under their wing and made them comfortable for the night. By that time Brigade HQ was becoming anxious about the fate of the gunners. The next day, after bidding 2 Rajput's Charlie Company goodbye, Talwar made his way to Brigade HQ (while the rest of party returned to the gun position at Tsangdhar) and into an extremely tense situation. He was present in the brigade when Dalvi spoke to Prasad on 19 October evening. After that Talwar pitched his tent outside the brigade and went to sleep, tucked into a sleeping bag.

After getting the news that the party, which had set off for Tsangle was safe, Behl heaved a sigh of relief. He looked forward to meeting Talwar and getting information on Chinese positions, even though the men who had returned from the aborted trip told him the Chinese were out of the range of their guns. The next morning, Behl watched helplessly as the Chinese attack developed in the valley below and the 1/9 GR positions ahead of him started getting shelled by heavy mortars and artillery. As the minutes went by, there was still no sign of Talwar, who had by then attached himself to Brigadier Dalvi's group. Shells soon started landing all around Behl's gun position as well.